

The Disintegration of Pakistan and the Emergence of Bangladesh: An Analysis of Factors and Disparities

1. Introduction

Bangladesh's emergence in 1971 resulted from decades of systemic exploitation. Pakistan's two wings were divided by distance and cultural differences, with East Pakistan treated as a colony.

2. Geographical and Demographical Disconnect

East Pakistan, with 56% of the population, was far from the political and military centers in West Pakistan, isolating its people from decision-making.

3. The Language Movement: Cultural Suppression

Attempts to impose Urdu over Bengali led to protests in 1952, sparking Bengali nationalism and emphasizing linguistic identity.

4. Economic Exploitation: The "Two-Economy" Theory

East Pakistan earned most foreign exchange, but wealth was spent in the West. Development and per capita income heavily favored West Pakistan.

5. Disparity in Planning and Infrastructure

Five-Year Plans prioritized West Pakistan; East remained agrarian. Around \$2.6 billion was effectively transferred to the West over two decades.

6. Administrative and Political Exclusion

Bengalis were underrepresented in civil and foreign services. Political moves like dismissing the United Front and imposing military rule marginalized them.

7. Military Imbalance and Defense Vulnerability

Bengalis had minimal representation in the military. Defense spending benefited West Pakistan, leaving East vulnerable during conflicts.

8. The Six-Point Movement and Agartala Conspiracy Case

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman demanded provincial autonomy. The Agartala Case (1968) united Bengalis and led to the 1969 Mass Upsurge against Ayub Khan.

9. The 1970 Cyclone and the Election Mandate

Bhola Cyclone relief was inadequate. The Awami League won a majority in the 1970 election, but power was denied, making separation inevitable.

10. Conclusion

Decades of exclusion, exploitation, and oppression forced Bengalis to seek independence. Bangladesh emerged as a nation demanding justice, equity, and democracy.